Mandatory AI in Higher Education

Gen-AI & Business Productivity

A Mandatory Subject in Higher & Professional Education

“Artificial intelligence has arrived in the workplace and has the potential to be as transformative as the steam engine was to the 19th-century Industrial Revolution” (McKinsey & Company)

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is revolutionizing industries and shaping the future of business. By covering a broad spectrum of AI concepts, this course equips learners with the foundational knowledge needed to understand and design AI solutions effectively. This course provides valuable insights and hands-on learning opportunities.

ICMA Digital

February 2026

23/02/2026

Gen-AI & Business Productivity

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Content

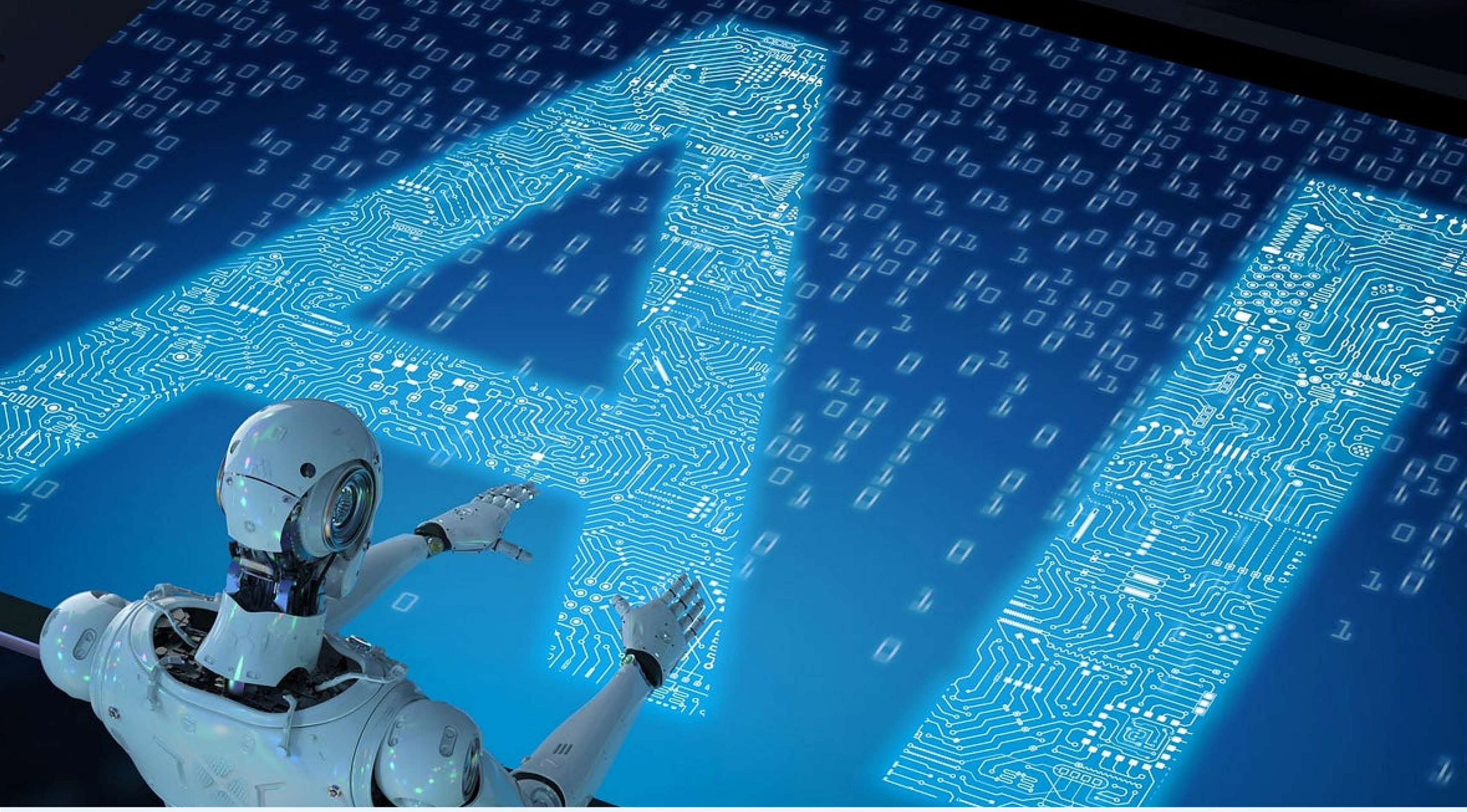
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23/02/2026

AI Mandatory Study in Higher Education

National Initiatives



KSA - Mandatory AI Study in Universities

In January 2026, Saudi Data & AI Authority (SDAIA) launched the National Cross-Disciplinary Curriculum for University Students in Data and AI — a mandatory programme for all undergraduates across every discipline. This is an important step towards building a future-ready workforce.

This marks a structural transformation in the Kingdom's higher education system. For the first time, AI literacy is embedded across all academic fields — not limited to computer science.

Whether studying engineering, business, medicine, education, or the humanities, every student will graduate with foundational skills in:

- **Responsible and ethical AI use**
- **Data literacy and analytical thinking**
- **Using AI tools to support learning, work, and decision-making**
- **Understanding AI applications relevant to their discipline**

Why Does it Matter?

The initiative addresses a critical global challenge: the gap between fast-advancing AI technologies and the ability of society to use them effectively.

By empowering non-specialists to apply AI in real-world contexts, Saudi Arabia is building a broad, AI-capable workforce capable of driving innovation across sectors.

The Big Picture

KSA and the UAE (please see page 10) now lead the region in AI education policy, with only China pursuing AI literacy at comparable national scale.

This reflects a wider shift: GCC countries are positioning human capital as the foundation of long-term competitiveness, aligning closely with Vision 2030 and national transformation goals.

By integrating AI education from childhood through university and into lifelong learning, Saudi Arabia is creating a generation equipped not only to use emerging technologies — but to shape them.

Source: Linked-in blog by the Former Foreign Minister of Uzbekistan





Pakistan - Mandatory AI Study in Universities

In February 2026, the Higher Education Commission ('HEC') announced that all degree programs from Fall 2026 must incorporate a mandatory 3-credit hour course on Artificial Intelligence (AI). This course may be offered as:

a) An elective subject;
b) An interdisciplinary course; or
c) An allied subject integrated within the program's structure

Commenting on the decision, HEC's Executive Director highlighted that Artificial Intelligence (AI) has emerged as a transformative force driving innovation across diverse sectors, including education, healthcare, economy, and governance. The significance of AI in the current era cannot be overstated; it is reshaping how we access, process and apply knowledge, enabling unprecedented advancements in problem-solving, efficiency, and decision-making. As the world advances towards an AI-integrated future, it is imperative for Pakistan's higher education system to equip students with the necessary skills to harness this technology responsibly and ethically.

The Strategic Objective

The integration of AI into curricula is not merely an enhancement but a necessity of the time. Without a foundational understanding of AI and its ethical implications, students' risk being left behind in a global knowledge economy that demands digital literacy and adaptability.

Ethical use of AI encompassing issues such as bias mitigation, data privacy, transparency, and societal impact is crucial to ensure that technological progress aligns with human values and sustainable development.

By embedding AI education, we empower students to apply these tools in their respective fields, fostering interdisciplinary innovation and aligning Pakistan's workforce with international standards.

Source: 18th February 2026 Memo from the Executive Director of HEC, Pakistan



AI Mandatory Study in Higher Education

Educational Institution Case Studies

Oxford University
Use of Gen-AI Tools to Support Learning

Part of what a university education teaches is certain academic skills, such as assimilating information, constructing an evidence-based argument and expressing your thoughts in clear, coherent prose.

AI tools cannot replace human critical thinking or the development of scholarly evidence-based arguments and subject knowledge that forms the basis of your university education.

You can make use of generative AI tools (e.g. ChatGPT, Claude, Bing Chat and Google Bard) in developing your academic skills to support your studies. Your ongoing critical appraisal of outputs by reviewing them for accuracy will maximise the potential for AI outputs to be a useful additional tool to support you in your studies.





UAE University - Mandatory AI Study

In May 2025, the UAE University (UAEU) announced the introduction of Artificial Intelligence (AI) courses as a core component of the mandatory university requirements for all students across various academic disciplines.

This initiative ensures that all university students, regardless of their field of study, receive foundational knowledge in AI and build their capacity to deal with modern technologies that have become integral to key sectors.

In September 2025, the University started offering four distinct introductory courses that address AI concepts and their applications in different areas. These courses are designed to align with the students' academic disciplines and future career interests.

The courses include the following: Introduction to Artificial Intelligence, AI Fundamentals and Applications, AI in Engineering, and AI in Medicine. Students select one of these courses based on their major and aspirations.

Estd. 1951

ICMA

Institute of Cost and Management Accountants of Pakistan

AI Paper in a Professional Accounting Body

In July 2025, ICMA Pakistan introduced Gen-AI as a part of its new curricula through ICMA Digital, its UK incorporated digital-first career development arm. ICMA Digital's mission is to develop job-ready workforce of the future with globally in-demand digital skills.

ICMA's new curricula aims to boost CMA job-readiness in today's fast-evolving business landscape, where technology is reshaping the traditional role of professional accountants.

As a first for accounting professional bodies in Pakistan, Gen-AI is included as a core subject in the new ICMA curricula to ensure that the new generation of CMAs has familiarity with the concept of Gen-AI and its potential impact on business productivity.

During 2026, ICMA Digital has the mandate to prepare 5,000+ students for assessments conducted by ICMA Pakistan.

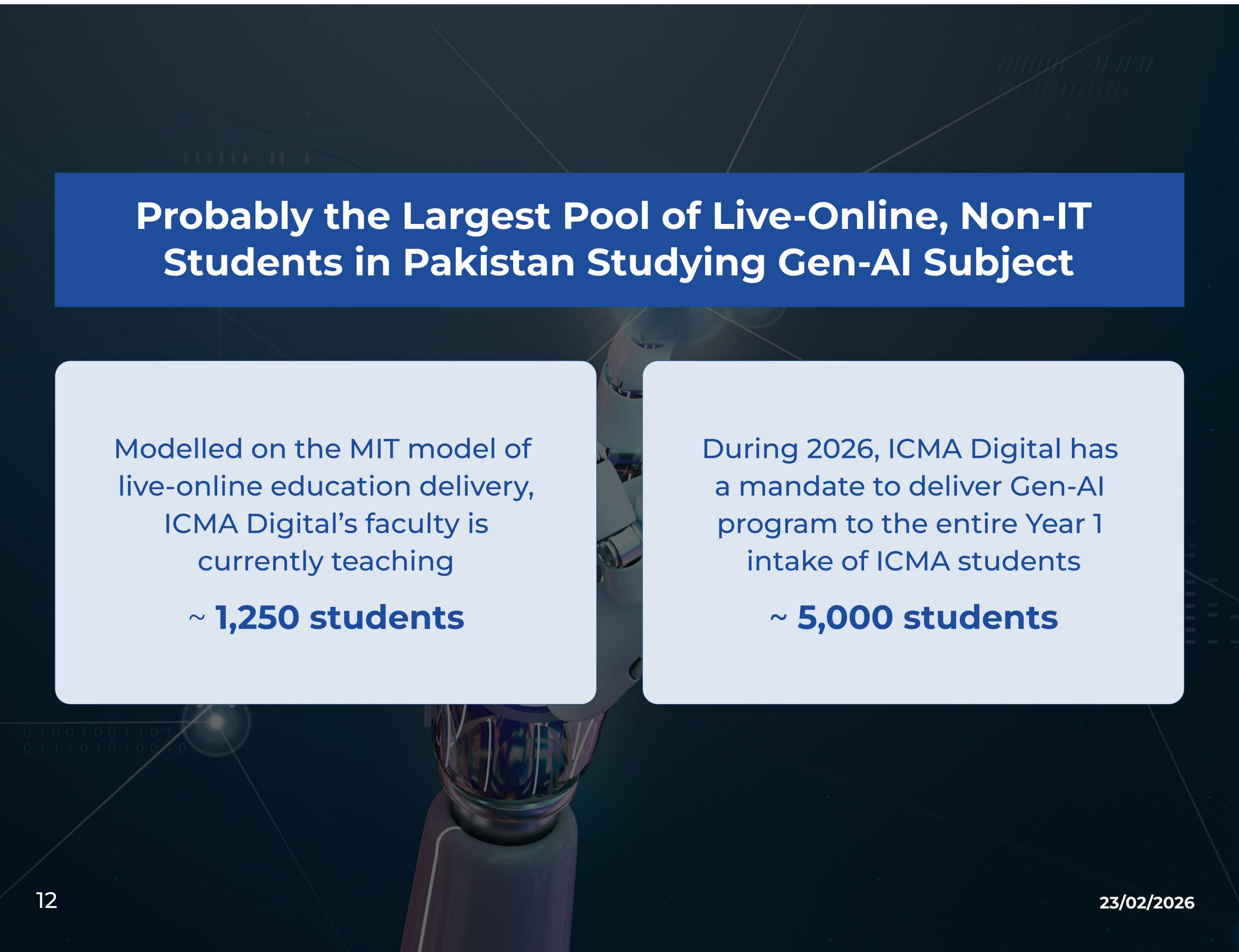
Gen-AI Teaching for ICMA Pakistan Students

During Q4-2025, ICMA Pakistan's student members started joining ICMA's mandatory Gen-AI program structured and delivered by ICMA Digital.

Students from 9 cities in Pakistan form each monthly cohort that meets for 3-hour classes three times a week (total 90 hours of faculty-led studies). The education is delivered on a live-online basis with the help of a national pool of faculty members who manage these cohorts with the same discipline as face-to-face teaching in universities.

Gen-AI Training in Saudi Arabia

ICMA Digital, in partnership with the Saudi Organisation for Chartered & Professional Accountants (SOCPA), conducted a 5-day training program on Gen-AI for the Accounting & Financial Services Professionals attended by 50 SOCPA members in Riyadh.



Probably the Largest Pool of Live-Online, Non-IT Students in Pakistan Studying Gen-AI Subject

Modelled on the MIT model of live-online education delivery, ICMA Digital's faculty is currently teaching

~ 1,250 students

During 2026, ICMA Digital has a mandate to deliver Gen-AI program to the entire Year 1 intake of ICMA students

~ 5,000 students

Program Composition & Learning Content Providers

Program Composition

PART	SYLLABUS CONTENT AREA	WEIGHTAGE
A	**Elements of AI** Chapter 1: What is AI? Chapter 2: AI problem solving Chapter 3: Real world AI Chapter 4: Machine learning Chapter 5: Neural networks Chapter 6: Implications	40%
B	**Gen-AI: Introduction & Applications** 1. Introduction and capabilities of generative AI 2. Applications and tools of Generative AI 3. Course Quiz, Project, and Wrap-up	10%
C	**Prompt Engineering for ChatGPT** 1. Course Introduction 2. Introduction to Prompts, Prompts Patterns 3. Prompts Patterns I 4. Few-Shots Prompt Example 5. Prompts Patterns II 6. Prompts Patterns III	20%
D	**Ethical AI: AI Essentials for Everyone** 1. Introduction & Principles of Ethical AI 2. AI Tools Discovery 3. Ethical Prompt Engineering 4. Living with AI - Challenges & Opportunities	10%
E	**Building AI-Powered Chatbots Without Programming** 1. Introduction to chatbots 2. Working with intents 3. Entities 4. Dialog 5. Deployment 6. Context Variables & slots 7. Digressions 8. Watson Actions	10%

Program Composition

PART	SYLLABUS CONTENT AREA	WEIGHTAGE
F	**Google AI Professional Certificate** 1. AI Fundamentals - Summary 2. AI for Brainstorming & Planning 3. AI for Research & Insights 4. AI for Writing & Communicating 5. AI for Content Creation 6. AI for Data Analysis 7. AI for App Building	10%

Learning Content Providers

Part - A Elements of AI	UNIVERSITY OF HELSINKI
Part - B Generative AI Introduction & Applications	IBM
Part - C Prompt Engineering for ChatGPT	VANDERBILT UNIVERSITY
Part - D Ethical AI: AI Essentials for Everyone	UNIVERSITY OF CAMBRIDGE
Part - E Building AI-Powered Chatbots without Programming	IBM
Part - F Google AI Professional Certificate	G

Live Online Education Delivery & Assessment

Live Online Education Delivery



Live Virtual Classes

While international learning content and video lectures from international tutors are used, the ICMA Digital's team of Mentors deliver a summary and proactively teach this learning content to the program participants in live online sessions. This approach allows the participants to benefit from the lecture style & content of international faculty, but at the same time listen to the summary lecture of the Mentors and conduct engaging interactions with the Mentors and their classmates in a virtual cohort.



Digital Access to the Learning Content

Unlike traditional classroom-based lectures & discussions where the learners rely on note-taking, all live online Zoom class sessions are recorded and made available to the program participants. This means that the learners can focus entirely on understanding the substance of the lecture & discussion without the need for any note taking. In addition to the class recordings, learners have access to the full set of the learning content (videos, readings and quizzes) through Coursera digital platforms prior to, and after the live online sessions, for self-paced review during the program.



Assignments, Projects & Assessment

The program is structured in a manner where the learner completes assignments, projects and on-going assessments (quizzes) during the live online sessions in the presence of Mentors.

To reinforce the learnings, some revision work is given to the participants before the next live online session.

ICMA Digital

Empowering Education with Intelligence.

Streamline cohort management, track real-time attendance, and gather actionable feedback insights in one unified platform.

- Real-time Analytics Dashboard
- Secure Student Data Management
- Instant Attendance Reports

Overview of Program Assessment

The Gen-Al & Business Productivity course has its primary focus on delivering applied learning skills. While it has a noticeable portion of learning focused on delivering 'knowledge', a majority of the program developed by IBM is focused on preparing the learner to be able to deploy the skills learned during the course.

As such, formative assessment plays a significant role in the overall assessment approach. Learners build their grade over the period of the course based on demonstrable and quantifiable continuous assessments.

However, they only become eligible to get the grade built on continuous assessment after passing two separate end of term exams: one for assessing knowledge and one focused on applied skills.



About ICMA Digital

ICMA Digital

Who We Are

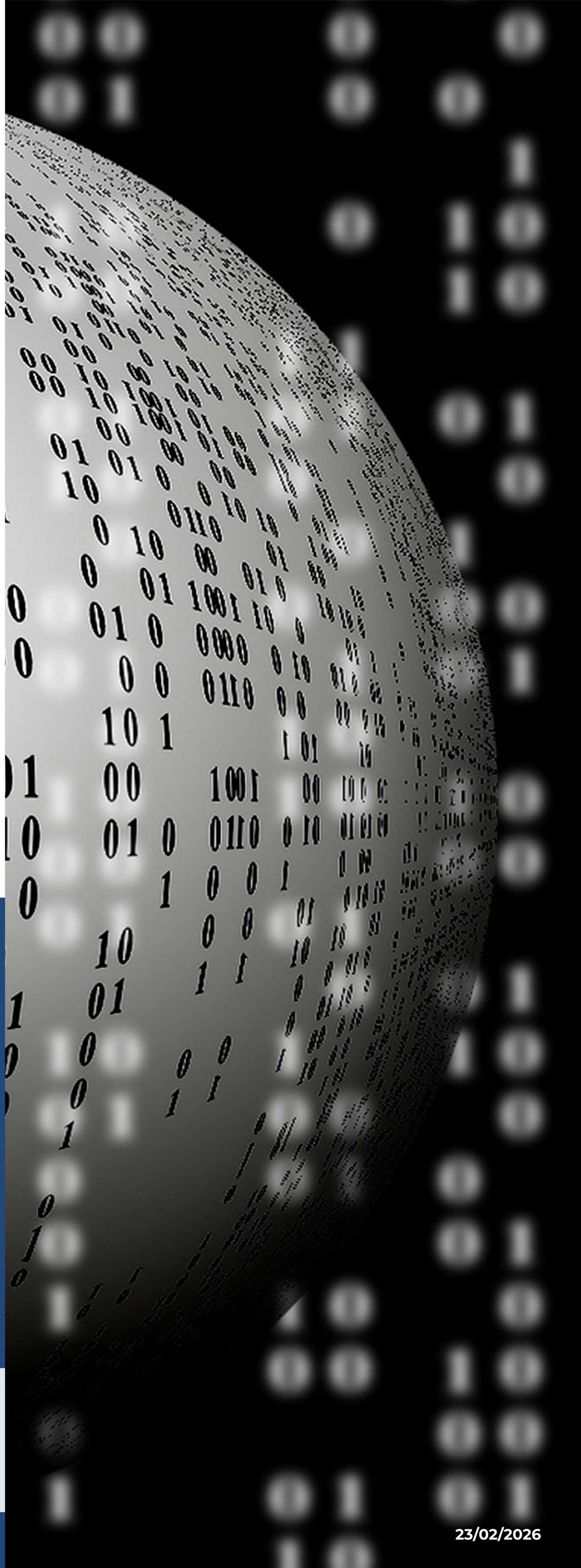
Incorporated in the UK, ICMA Digital Academy Limited is the Digital-first career development arm of the Institute of Cost & Management Accountants of Pakistan (ICMA).

ICMA has circa 7,500 full members and approximately 17,500 student members on the pathway to become future Chartered Management Accountants.

Our Mission

Develop job-ready workforce of the future with globally in-demand digital skills.

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